

 Government officials will never ask you to transfer money or disclose bank log-in details over a phone call.
Call the 24/7 ScamShield Helpline at 1799 if you are unsure if something is a scam.





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Cybersecurity and Scam Prevention

Top 5 scams in Singapore & how to avoid them (2025)

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Scams on the rise! Learn about the different types of scams targeting millennials and Zoomers. Equip yourself with the knowledge to protect your finances today!



Millennials and Zoomers are often referred to as digital natives as they are the first generations that grew up having the internet at their fingertips.

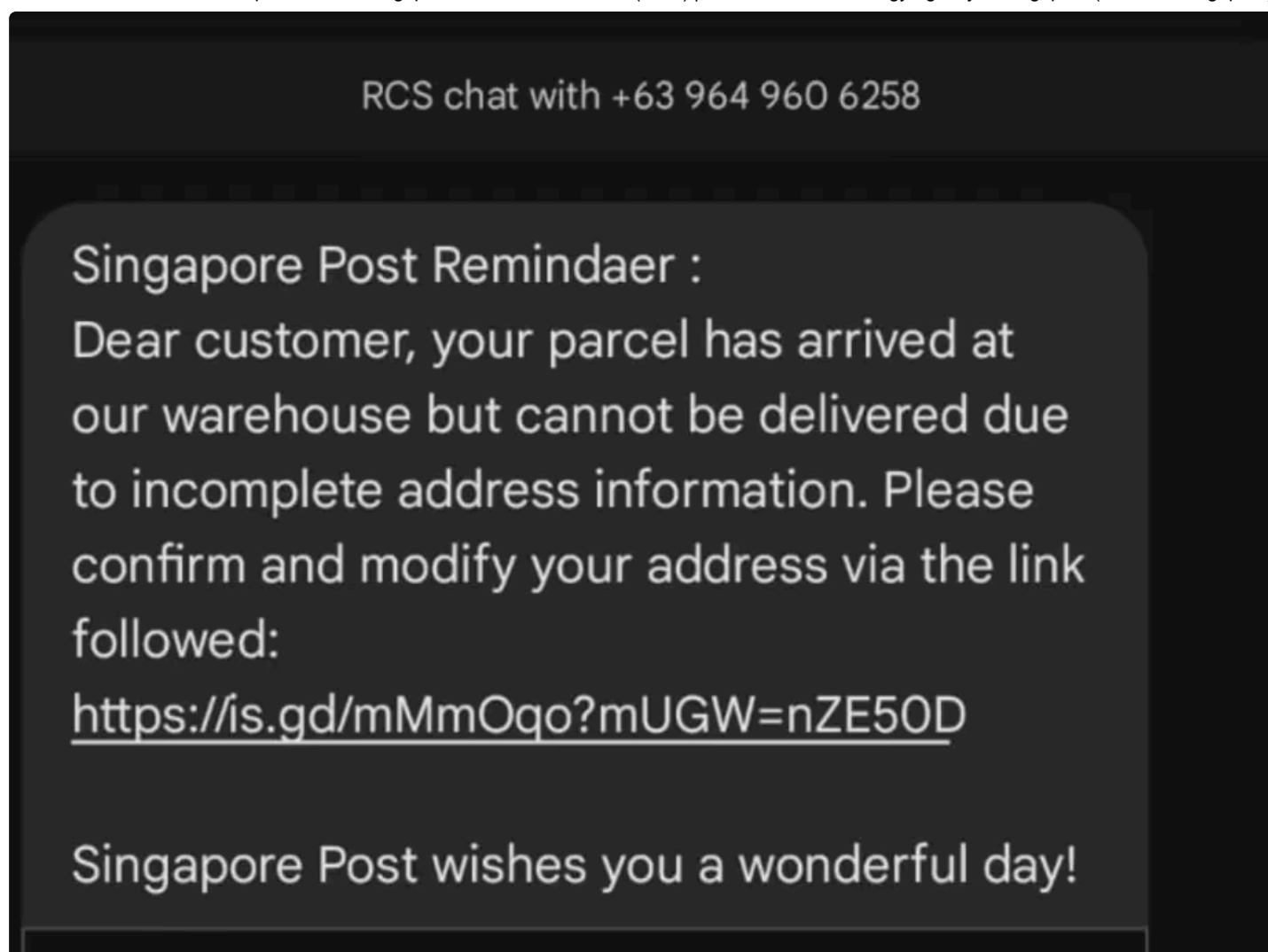
But if you think that being digital natives means being too savvy to fall victim to scams, think again. [Statistics](#) from the Singapore Police show that just over half of scam victims in 2022 are between 20 and 39 years old.

So it's time to shake off your complacency, young adults, and learn about the common scams out there. Arm yourself with knowledge so that you don't end up losing your hard-earned money!

1. Phishing scams

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How it works:

Phishing scams try to trick you into revealing your personal information like your login credentials or credit card details.

In such cases, scammers impersonate trusted organisations – such as banks and government agencies – to contact victims, urging them to disclose their personal information by creating a false sense of urgency (“You have one day to enter your password to claim a prize/complete your purchase/prevent your account from being deleted”).

Bogus websites and apps that closely resemble legitimate ones could also be created, fooling victims into believing that they are logging into their real accounts.

Example – OCBC phishing scam

One of the most serious cases of phishing scams hit OCBC bank account holders in [2021](#).

They received SMSes claiming that they needed to click on a link to resolve an issue with their bank accounts. Those who clicked the link were redirected to fake bank websites and asked to key in their online banking login details. These credentials were then used to transfer large sums of money out of their accounts.

A total of 790 OCBC customers fell victim to the scam, losing \$13.7 million altogether. The bank [fully reimbursed](#) the victims, after acknowledging its customer service and response fell short.

How to protect yourself:

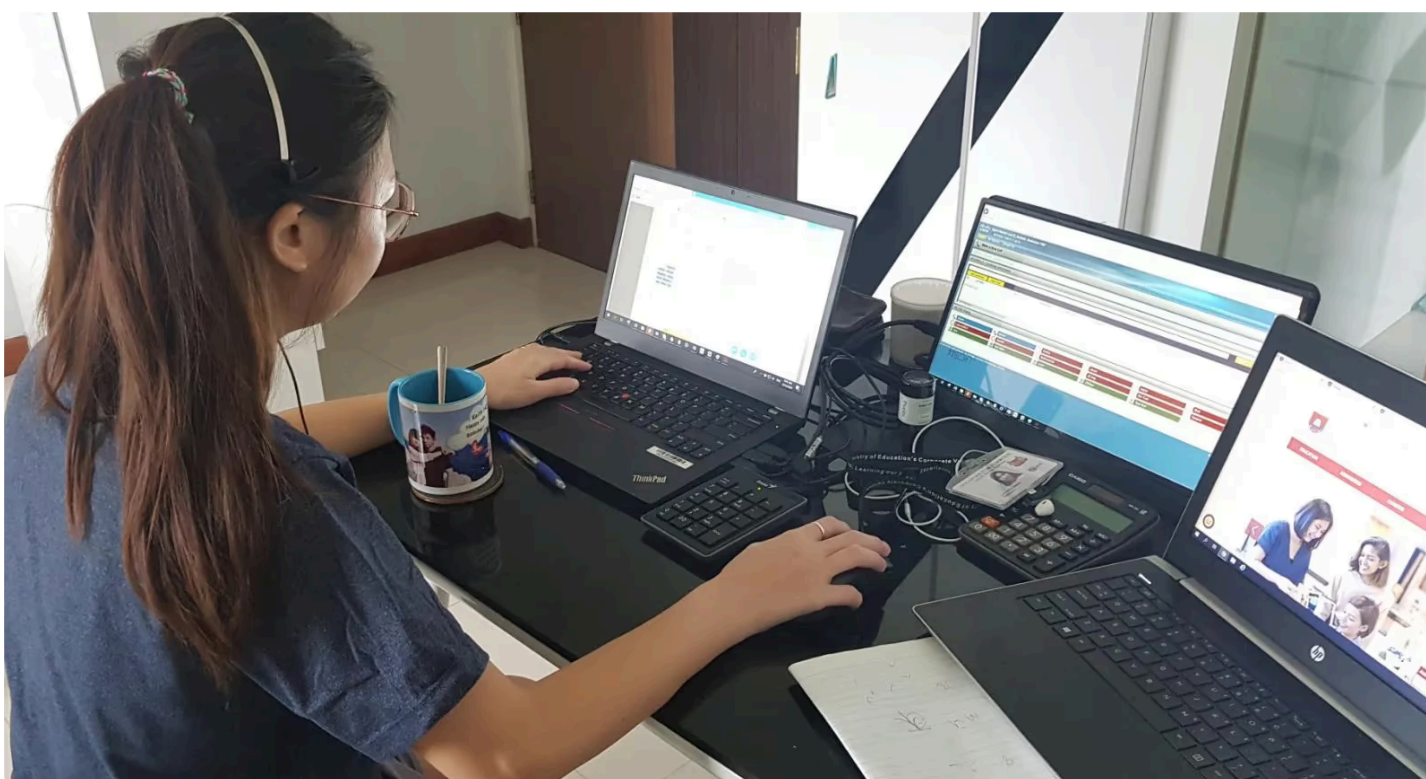
- Always verify the app or website you are logging into. Look out for telltale signs like misspellings in the URL.
- Scammers can use a method called [spoofing](#) to send SMSes and make them appear in the same thread of real SMSes from the legitimate organisation. So, never trust an SMS just because it appears together with other SMSes you know for sure are from a legitimate organisation.
- Never reveal your password or one-time password over the phone; legitimate organisations will never do that.

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- As mentioned above, phishing scams exploit fear – whether it's fear of missing out on a great opportunity or fear of losing something precious. Take a moment to breathe and check if the entity contacting you is really who they say they are. For example, legitimate bank customer service agents will gladly oblige your efforts to verify their identity, and won't dissuade you from hanging up to call the bank back so you know you're really talking to bank representatives.
- Legitimate websites should have the *https* in the address bar. Banks have stopped sending SMSes and emails with links to click. If you receive a message full of links purportedly from a bank, it's highly likely to be a scam.
- Whilst secure websites typically start with 'https' instead of 'http', users are also advised to check that other security indicators are in place as well. Always exercise caution and verify the authenticity of any communication through official channels before taking action.
- Refer to the Government's [list of trusted sites](#) when logging in to access government services.

2. Job scams



How it works:

Scammers reach out to would-be victims on popular messaging apps such as Telegram and WhatsApp, offering simple work that can be done from home for easy money.

Such “jobs” typically involve liking social media posts, completing online surveys, or leaving product reviews.

Participants usually get paid a commission upon completing their first “task”, leading them to believe the job opportunity is real. Once the scammers gain the victims’ trust, they eventually concoct some task that involves the victims transferring their own money to a bank account provided by the scammers. The victims are promised their money back plus a commission for their efforts, only for the scammers to disappear on them.

Example – Purchasing task scam

About \$20 million were lost to [job scams in May 2023](#), said the police in an effort to alert the public. These scams offer fake job opportunities involving online purchases.

Victims receive these offers through unsolicited WhatsApp or Telegram messages, asking them to complete simple surveys. Once they receive their initial payment and commission, they are told they have to boost a product’s popularity by buying it online.

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However, the victims are instructed to make payments not through the website's payment modes but to bank accounts provided by the scammers via online messaging platforms.

Other victims are tasked with signing into an account to buy cryptocurrencies, with the bogus rationale of stimulating the crypto market.

In the end, the victims end up shelling out money but not receiving the promised returns.

How to protect yourself:

- Dubious claims of easy money should not be trusted.
- Such "job offers" typically involve downloading apps of unknown origins. Doing so will not only open you up to scams, but may also compromise the security of your phone.
- If potential employers require payment before you can start work, run for the hills!
- Some scammers will even add victims to group chats, claiming that the other members are working on the same tasks. The group members encourage each other to carry out the tasks and post screenshots showing the commission they receive. These group members may very well be in on the scam and are trying to lull victims into a false sense of security.

3. E-commerce scams

How it works:

With online shopping becoming ever more popular, e-commerce scams are also proliferating. Scammers post listings of products for sale on shopping platforms or advertisements on social media, with eye-catching discounts and prices way below normal retail prices.

These fraudulent sellers disappear on the buyers once payment has been made.

There are also cases where buyers are told to download an app to facilitate payment, not knowing that the app contains malware that compromises the buyers' online accounts.

Example – Seafood scam

A 62-year-old man [lost more than \\$40,000 ↗](#) of his Central Provident Fund (CPF) savings after trying to buy seafood through a Facebook ad.

After clicking the ad, he was taken to a website where he failed to buy anything. He then found a WhatsApp number on the site, which he used to contact the seller. The seller sent a link that was supposed to be an order form, but after the victim clicked on it, an app appeared on the victim's phone.

The victim found this a little unusual but thought nothing more of it as the seller eventually offered to take the victim's seafood order over the phone directly. After ending the call, the victim tried but failed to delete the app, and eventually gave up and went to sleep.

The next morning, he discovered that his CPF savings had been transferred to his bank account and then transferred out.

How to protect yourself:

- Once again, don't be tempted by rock-bottom prices. Ask yourself, how is it that the seller can afford to sell the goods at a much lower price than competitors?
- Shop at established shopping platforms. Even then, be sure to choose verified sellers, official brand stores, and comb through the reviews carefully.

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- Beware of links sent to you by sellers claiming they need to perform extra steps to confirm your purchase.
- If you suspect there's malware on your device, turn on flight mode immediately to disable any malicious connections. Perform an anti-virus/anti-malware scan. Do a factory reset to be sure.
- Unfortunately, Android phones are more susceptible to malware attacks due to the open nature of the Android platform. Android phones can also download apps from sources other than the official Google Play Store. Still, it does not mean that iPhone users are immune from malware. All smart device users should still be vigilant about strange, unfamiliar apps appearing on their devices.

4. Investment Scams

How it works:

These are get-rich-quick schemes promising high returns for investments in anything from cryptocurrency, overseas real estate, and even [durians](#). ↗

Those who take part in the investment may even initially earn a profit (are you seeing a pattern now?), leading them to believe that the investment is legitimate and enticing them to pour larger amounts of money in.

This is when the scammers either pull a disappearing act, or start making claims that the victims need to cough up more money (in the guise of a handling/admin fee) before they can withdraw their investment. In reality, this is just yet another trick to string victims along and milk them for as long as possible.

Example – Investment scam using prominent economist's name

Fraudsters impersonated well-known economist Tan Khee Giap and set up social media accounts and WhatsApp groups. In these channels, the bogus Dr Tan would give investment tips on gold, futures and foreign currencies.

The scammers would also instruct members to go to a website that they claimed was an online investment platform. One victim invested nearly \$25,000 over three weeks and supposedly doubled her money. But when she tried to do a partial withdrawal, she was rejected by the system. She was then told she had to pay a "handling fee" of 10 per cent, or \$2,477. After she transferred the money, the scammers became uncontactable.

How to protect yourself:

- Check with official sources and do investments only with licensed financial advisers. It is extremely unlikely that prominent figures will be running private investment groups.
- Don't be taken in by initial positive gains, especially if these are paper gains.
- As with all investments, do your due diligence. Legitimate investment opportunities are usually well-publicised in reputable media outlets or official sources.

5. Fake friend call scams

How it works:

Getting a call from a friend you haven't heard from in a while is always nice, provided that friend is indeed your friend. Scammers are calling unsuspecting victims, claiming to be their friend and asking questions like "Can you guess who I am?" and "You can't remember me?".

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Once the victim replies with the names of friends that could conceivably be the caller, the scammer latches on to one of the names and assumes that identity.

He then proceeds to ask for a loan, making up an excuse such as being stranded overseas and losing his money and phone (which conveniently explains why he's calling from an unknown number). Once the victim agrees to help, the scammer provides a means of transferring money, and is never heard from again.

Fake friend call scams have increased at an [astonishing pace ↗](#), going from zero reported cases in 2020 to 2,106 cases in 2022, with victims losing at least \$8.8 million.

Example – Asking for a favour

A [new variant ↗](#) of this scam observed by the police this year involves scammers asking for favours instead of money. Once the scammer tricks the victim into believing he is a friend, he asks if the victim can help with a simple task such as making a purchase, a restaurant reservation, or tracking a missing phone.

The scammer then proceeds to send malicious links, which will lead the victim to phishing sites or download malware to the victim's phone, enabling the scammer to gain control of the device.

More than 3,700 people fell prey to such scams and lost at least \$12 million in the first half of 2023.

How to protect yourself:

- Be sceptical of people contacting you out of the blue, claiming to be someone you know but yet playing coy about who they are.
- Try contacting the friend back using other means, such as a phone number or social media, to verify if it is indeed him or her trying to contact you.
- Reach out to mutual friends, too, to check about this friend. Your mutual friend may be in closer contact with said friend and know for sure he is safely at work rather than stranded in the Maldives.

Prevalence of WhatsApp Scams in Singapore



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It's no secret that WhatsApp has become a hotspot for scammers in Singapore, and we've seen a worrying surge in WhatsApp scams lately. You might be thinking, "But I only chat with friends and family on WhatsApp!" That's precisely why it's so effective.

The platform's popularity and the trust we place in it make it a prime target. Scammers know we're more likely to believe a message from a "friend" or a "familiar organisation." They bank on that trust to trick us, and unfortunately, it works far too often.

Think of it this way: WhatsApp is like a bustling marketplace. Lots of people, lots of opportunities, and unfortunately, lots of chances for tricksters to blend in. They might pretend to be your bank, a government agency, or even a friend in need. They'll use urgency, fear, or even flattery to get you to act without thinking. They might ask for your OTP, a password, or tell you to transfer money to a "safe" account. It's all a ruse. We need to remember that just because a message comes through WhatsApp, it doesn't mean it's genuine.

Common tactics of WhatsApp scams

- **WhatsApp OTP Hijacking Scams:** Scammers trick victims into sharing their OTP, gaining access to their accounts.
- **Fake WhatsApp Links:** Malicious links lead to phishing sites or malware downloads.
- **Impersonation of Friends/Family or Organisations:** Scammers pose as known contacts, requesting money or personal information.

How to protect yourself:

- Enable two-factor authentication (2FA) on WhatsApp to add an extra layer of security. To do this, go to WhatsApp settings, then account, and finally, 2-step verification.
- Be cautious of unsolicited messages requesting personal information or money transfers.
- Verify the identity of unknown contacts by calling them directly or contacting a mutual friend.
- Never click on suspicious links or download attachments from unknown senders.
- Report suspicious activity to [ScamShield](#). Download the ScamShield app via the official app store and report any suspicious numbers or messages.
- Keep your WhatsApp application updated to ensure you have the latest security patches, an important part of overall [scam prevention](#).
- Be careful of messages that create a false sense of urgency. Slow down and think before taking any action.
- If you encounter a number used in a scam, add it to a reputable scammer list in Singapore, if available, to help warn others.

Constant vigilance against a growing menace

In 2022, scam victims lost about \$660 million, almost \$30 million more than in 2021. And this problem will only grow as our lives become increasingly digital, creating more opportunities for scammers to strike.

That is why it's imperative we do our part as individuals to educate ourselves, watch out for one another, and report suspicious activity.

Remember, If something even feels a whiff strange, don't proceed. If it's too good to be true, it probably isn't.

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